
DARED – 2024 Annual Report

Direct Action for Rights and Equity Development

2024 ANNUAL REPORT

Bringing Change and Development, One Community at a Time.

A Message from the Director

As we reflect on the past year, it is with profound gratitude and a deep sense of accomplishment that I present this 2024 annual report. We embarked on the year with a clear objective: to deepen our impact through a series of engaging, interactive, and innovative activities. Looking back, I am filled with immense pride in what we have achieved together, staying true to our foundational mission of bringing change and development, one community at a time.

This year saw DARED at the forefront of critical community initiatives. We engaged local stakeholders to advance women's empowerment, championed heritage conservation as an essential tool for preserving cultural identity, and worked diligently to elevate the theatre arts within the Northwest Region. Our commitment to the next generation was realized through vibrant arts and craft trainings for children, equipping them with valuable skills and creative outlets for a more resilient future. These programs are about more than just art; they are about building confidence and community.

Through key partnerships, we delivered high-impact project management and grant writing trainings for artists in Bamenda, and most notably, we took a leading role in implementing the UNESCO World Heritage Volunteer Fund project at the Bafut Royal Palace. It was a profound responsibility to work on a site of such immense cultural importance.

On a personal note, I was honored to participate in a creative filmmaking workshop at the U.S. Embassy, which culminated in directing my first documentary on the challenges facing young creatives in Cameroon. The power of visual storytelling to advocate for change is immense. I was also privileged to speak at the World Heritage Day celebration, an experience that reinforced the importance of our collective work.

None of this would be possible without the unwavering support of our partners, volunteers, and community members. Your belief in our mission is the engine that drives us forward. 2024 has been an amazing year of growth and impact, but we are just getting started. The foundation we have laid gives us immense confidence as we look toward a better, more impactful 2025.

Our Mission, Vision & 2024 at a Glance

Our Mission

Direct Action for Rights and Equity Development (DARED) is a dynamic non-profit organization dedicated to fostering sustainable and vibrant communities in Cameroon. We believe in creating positive change through hands-on engagement, meaningful collaboration, and the preservation of cultural heritage for future generations.

Our Vision

We envision a developed Cameroon where cultural heritage is celebrated as a cornerstone of identity and economic opportunity, where the arts are a powerful tool for advocacy and peacebuilding, and where every young person has the skills and confidence to build a resilient future.

Our Approach

We believe in grassroots, community-led methodology. Our projects are designed in collaboration with the people they serve, ensuring that our interventions are relevant, respectful, and sustainable. We act as facilitators, empowering local leaders and creatives to become agents of their own development.

2024 at a Glance

This year was defined by strategic action and impactful collaboration. Our key achievements include:

Led the high-profile implementation of the UNESCO World Heritage Volunteer Fund project at the Bafut Royal Palace, engaging youth in tangible restoration work.

Enhanced the professional capacity of local artists by delivering targeted training in project management and successful grant writing.

Empowered over 50 children through holistic holiday workshops covering arts, crafts, music, dance, and essential computer skills.

Fostered economic resilience for artisans in Bafut by developing new strategies for branding, marketing, and accessing alternative markets.

Spearheaded cultural advocacy and public awareness campaigns, including radio appearances and educational tours, to celebrate World Heritage Day.

Strengthened the regional creative industry by participating in and contributing to a high-level Film for Advocacy workshop.

Championed the performing arts by co-organizing events to celebrate and elevate the vital role of theatre in the Northwest Region.

In-Depth Look: Heritage Preservation & Cultural Advocacy

The UNESCO World Heritage Volunteer Fund Project

A cornerstone of our work in 2024 was our esteemed partnership with the Regional Delegation of Arts and Culture in implementing the UNESCO World Heritage Volunteer Fund project. This vital initiative centered on the Bafut Royal Palace, one of only two sites in the Northwest Region on UNESCO's Tentative List of World Heritage Sites, making its preservation a matter of regional and national importance.

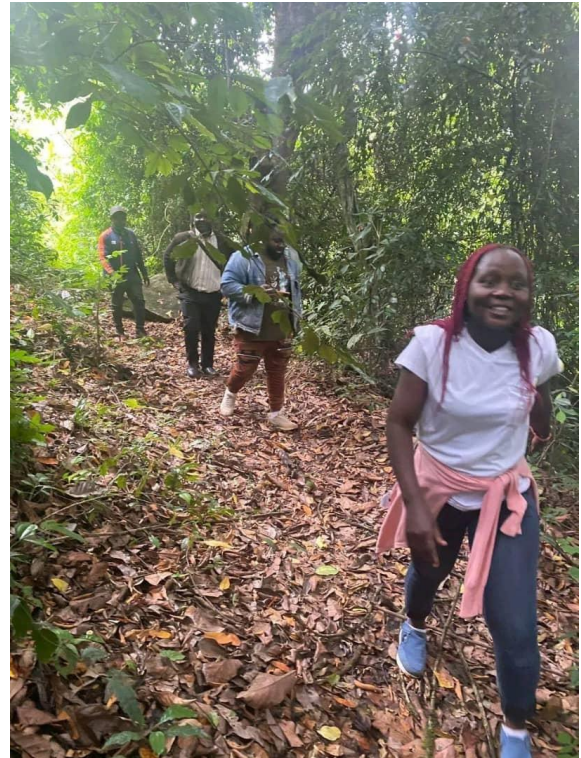


The project's primary goal was to leverage volunteerism as a powerful catalyst for heritage restoration. By directly involving young volunteers, we aimed to instill a profound sense of ownership and participation in protecting their cultural identity. Volunteers learned practical skills in traditional building techniques, documentation, and public speaking, becoming true ambassadors for heritage. This project serves not only to restore a key site but also as a replicable model for community-led conservation efforts across the region.

Commemorating World Heritage Day

DARED played a central and visible role in the celebration of the International Day for Monuments and Sites. Our activities commenced with a featured segment on the CRTV radio program "Yours and Mine," where we educated a wide audience on the day's historical significance and its specific relevance within our local context.

Following the broadcast, we organized an immersive educational tour for history and archaeology students from the University of Bamenda. The tour included visits to a 112-year-old German fort and the majestic Menteh Waterfall. The students' engagement was palpable, with a dynamic question-and-answer session with the sub-chief of Menteh village demonstrating a newfound appreciation for their local history. This experience successfully bridged the gap between academic theory and the living, breathing heritage of their own communities.



In-Depth Look: Empowering Creatives & Artisans

A Visit to the Bafut Palace & Support for Local Artisans

Our engagement at the Bafut Palace extended beyond the UNESCO project into direct economic empowerment. We facilitated a strategic meeting with local producers of the *Atogho*, a culturally significant textile that represents the heart of the region's design heritage. This crucial dialogue was chaired by the Fon of Bafut, lending significant weight to our discussions.



The meeting focused on actionable strategies to invigorate the local embroidery sector. Key outcomes included developing plans to support designers, establishing SMEs, and forging connections to attract investment. This direct dialogue is a crucial first step in building a sustainable local economy that honors traditional craftsmanship. A critical focus was placed on finding alternative markets for artisans whose livelihoods have been severely impacted by regional instability and a decline in tourism, providing a tangible pathway toward resilience.

Film for Advocacy Workshop

DARED was proud to participate in the "Film for Advocacy" workshop hosted by Noble Arts Entertainment at the U.S. Embassy. This intensive program gathered aspiring filmmakers from across Cameroon to master the craft of using film for social change.

This immersive experience went beyond technical skills, fostering a vital network of creative allies who can collaborate on future projects that challenge narratives and inspire action. A direct and proud outcome was the production of a short documentary directed by our team, which explores the significant challenges faced by young creatives in Cameroon. This project exemplifies our commitment to using art to advocate for the arts, giving a powerful voice to an often-overlooked segment of our society.





In-Depth Look: Youth & Community Capacity Building

Project Management & Grant Writing Training

Recognizing a critical skills gap within the artistic community, DARED organized a targeted training workshop in Bamenda focused on project management and grant writing. This initiative was designed to equip talented artists with the essential business and administrative acumen required to transform their creative visions into sustainable, fundable projects. By providing these tools, we empower them to move from dependency to self-sufficiency, becoming active agents in their own creative careers and contributing more robustly to the local economy.



Youth Empowerment through Arts & Crafts

During school holidays, DARED, in partnership with the Regional Delegation of Arts and Culture, delivered a comprehensive one-month training program for over 50 children. The workshops covered a diverse range of disciplines, from music and dance to embroidery and computer programming. This program provided a safe, constructive environment for children, allowing them to develop new skills and foster their creativity. By bringing children from diverse backgrounds together, the program also actively fostered friendships, mutual respect, and a shared sense of community achievement, planting the seeds for future social cohesion.





DIRECT ACTION FOR RIGHTS EQUITY AND DEVELOPMENT

**“DEVELOPING HOLISTIC APPROACHES FOR COMMUNITY
DEVELOPMENT, ONE COMMUNITY AT A TIME”**

REG No: 0012/19/RAG/NWR/RDAC/SAPCECI

Website: www.idared.org/

EMAIL: info@idared.org

Tel: 658197275/673757054

Promotion of Theatre Arts

In celebration of World Theatre Day, DARED co-organized an event that brought together youth and aspiring actors to explore the theme of "The Artist and Peace Consolidation." The event served as a vital platform for stakeholders and veterans to encourage the next generation of performers. We reaffirmed theatre's crucial role as a mirror to society and a safe space for dialogue on complex issues like peace and reconciliation. The day concluded with inspiring performances, demonstrating the vibrant talent and enduring spirit of our local theatre community.





DIRECT ACTION FOR RIGHTS EQUITY AND DEVELOPMENT

**“DEVELOPING HOLISTIC APPROACHES FOR COMMUNITY
DEVELOPMENT, ONE COMMUNITY AT A TIME”**

REG No: 0012/19/RAG/NWR/RDAC/SAPCECI

Website: www.idared.org/

EMAIL: info@idared.org

Tel: 658197275/673757054

Conclusion and Recommendations

General Appraisal of the Year

The year 2024 marked a period of strategic growth, impactful collaboration, and profound community transformation for the Direct Action for Rights and Equity Development (DARED). Operating at the vital intersection of cultural heritage preservation and grassroots community development, the organization successfully converted local challenges into resilient opportunities.

Key milestone figures from this year's performance metrics include:

- 1 High-Profile Implementation: Safely executed the UNESCO World Heritage Volunteer Fund project at the Bafut Royal Palace, actively engaging regional youth in tangible, hand-on restoration structures.
- Over 100 Children Empowered: Delivered a holistic one-month holiday workshop covering arts, crafts, music, dance, and essential computer skills to foster future social cohesion.
- 30+ Creative Minds Trained: Multiplied professional capacity in the artistic sector through a rigorous, targeted Project Management and Grant Writing Training in Bamenda to facilitate economic self-sufficiency.
- 2 Unique Advocacy Milestones: Directed a debut documentary film targeting challenges faced by young local creatives, alongside leading public education campaigns for World Heritage Day via CRTV radio broadcasts.

Strategic Recommendations for 2025

To capitalize on the momentum generated in 2024 and maximize operational scaling, the following strategic actions are highly recommended for the upcoming operational cycle:

- Scalability of Volunteer Models: Standardize the successful Bafut Royal Palace volunteer framework into a replicable toolkit to scale community-led conservation projects across other tentative heritage locations in Cameroon.



DIRECT ACTION FOR RIGHTS EQUITY AND DEVELOPMENT

**“DEVELOPING HOLISTIC APPROACHES FOR COMMUNITY
DEVELOPMENT, ONE COMMUNITY AT A TIME”**

REG No: 0012/19/RAG/NWR/RDAC/SAPCECI

Website: www.idared.org/

EMAIL: info@idared.org

Tel: 658197275/673757054

- Digital Marketplaces for Artisans: Establish a dedicated online promotional platform or e-commerce avenue specifically tailored for local Atogho textile weavers to safeguard alternative, secure economic markets amid local structural instability.
- Institutionalize Funding Networks: Build on partnerships secured with the Regional Delegation of Arts and Culture and the U.S. Embassy to create an ongoing, multi-year funding stream for creative advocacy programs.
- Expanded Tech-Art Integration: Enlarge the youth training model by blending core creative training with digital monetization literacy, expanding basic computer training into advanced web presence development for youth.

Final Outlook

By cementing these foundational practices, DARED enters 2025 exceptionally positioned to amplify its grassroots footprint. The organization remains an invaluable facilitator, actively shifting local narratives and empowering local creatives to serve as the direct architects of their own economic development.

TAMFU KILEM BONGWA
DIRECTOR